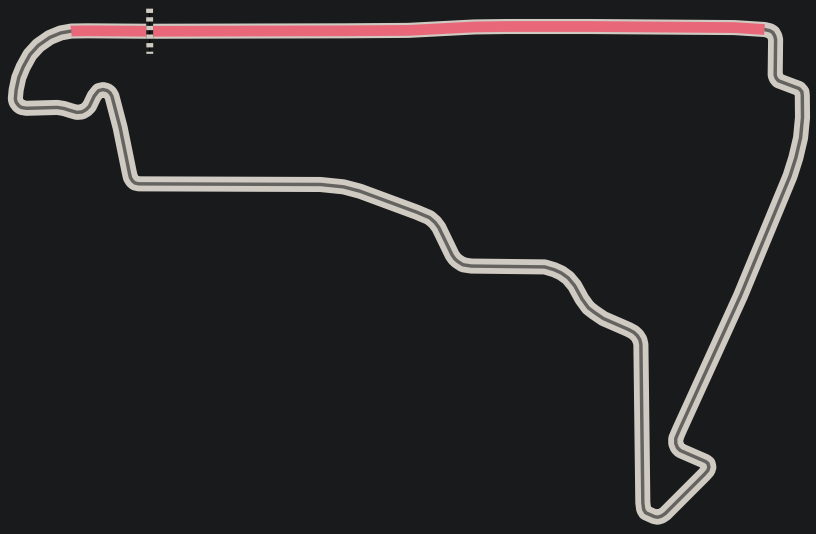
JP Motorsport Journal
EST. 2026 · JP RACE DAY PROGRAMME

EDITION
02
ROUND 19 OF 23

JP RACE DAY · MEXICO CITY GRAND PRIX

Coronation in Mexico City?



SUNDAY 1 NOVEMBER 2026 AUTÓDROMO HERMANOS RODRÍGUEZ · MEXICO CITY RACE 14:00 CST

Kimi Antonelli arrives in Mexico City 123 points clear with 125 left. A top-nine finish on Sunday makes him world champion, whatever anyone else does.

Antonelli won from pole in Austin, his ninth win of the season, and leaves Texas two points short of the title. Behind him, nine points cover Russell, Hamilton, Verstappen and Leclerc in the fight for second, and Red Bull have drawn level with McLaren for third in the Constructors'. Mexico City is a standard weekend at the highest track on the calendar: three practice sessions, qualifying on Saturday and the 71-lap race on Sunday.

01 **Antonelli's title point** ANALYSIS

After Mexico, 100 points remain. Ninth place or better makes Antonelli champion whatever anyone does; with no points, only a win for Russell or Hamilton keeps it alive.

02 **Four drivers, nine points** VERIFIED

Russell (242), Hamilton (241), Verstappen (236) and Leclerc (233) are separated by nine points in the fight to finish runner-up.

03 **Pérez at home** VERIFIED

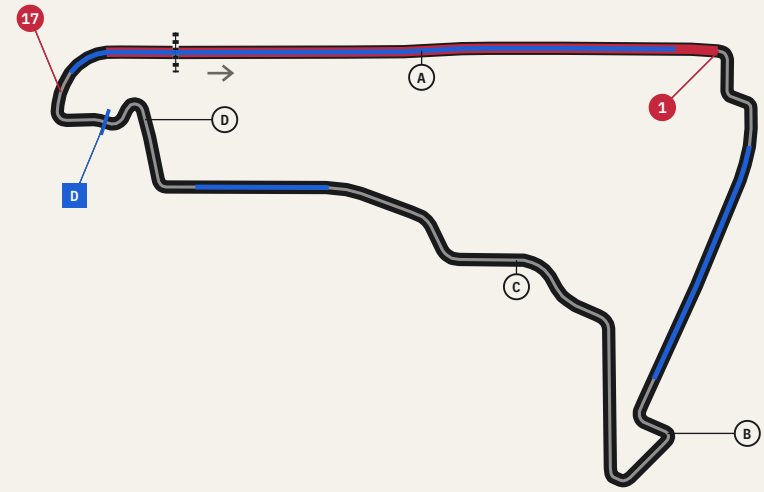
It is Sergio Pérez's home race, in his first season with Cadillac. Red Bull and McLaren arrive level on 355 points for third in the Constructors'.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5
Antonelli	Russell	Hamilton	Verstappen	Leclerc
365	242	241	236	233

02 · THE CIRCUIT FILE

Autódromo Hermanos Rodríguez

Seventeen corners, clockwise, more than 2,200 metres above sea level: a long run to Turn 1, a sequence of esses and a finish through the old baseball stadium.



Ⓐ Main straight Ⓑ Turns 4–6 Ⓒ Esses Ⓓ Stadium section

Straight Mode zone D Overtake detection

Zones at approximate positions, from the FIA's description; detection 3,871 m into the lap.

Red: start/finish straight · Arrow: direction of travel · Numbered: corners confirmed from the official outline; full numbering pending a check against the FIA map. Outline: f1-circuits (MIT).

CIRCUIT LENGTH	4.304 km VERIFIED
RACE LAPS	71 VERIFIED
RACE DISTANCE	305.354 km VERIFIED
CORNERS	17 (run clockwise) VERIFIED
FIRST GRAND PRIX	1963 VERIFIED
RACE LAP RECORD	1:17.774, Valtteri Bottas (2021) VERIFIED
LONGEST STRAIGHT	about 1.3 km, final corner to Turn 1 MEASURED

Overtaking aids VERIFIED
Three Straight Mode zones: the main straight into Turn 1, after Turn 3, and after Turn 11. Overtake Mode detection is mid-Turn 15, with activation mid-Turn 17 onto the main straight.

Turn 1 ANALYSIS

The longest run to a first corner on the calendar ends in a right-left-right complex. Slipstreams make it three wide on the opening lap, and the escape roads catch anyone who brakes too late.

Thin air ESTIMATE

At over 2,200 metres the air is roughly a fifth to a quarter thinner than at sea level. Cars run maximum-downforce settings yet carry less grip, and brakes and power units are harder to cool.

The esses ANALYSIS

A quick left-right sequence from Turn 7 rewards a car that changes direction cleanly. Drivers who slide here overheat the soft compounds Pirelli has brought.

Stadium section VERIFIED

The lap finishes through the old baseball stadium, tight and slow, in front of the biggest crowd of the weekend, before the final corner onto the main straight.

> **With grip low and the straight so long, the exit of the final corner sets up the run to Turn 1: a car that is close there can use the slipstream all the way down.** ANALYSIS

Terms used in this programme

Undercut Pitting before a rival to use new tyres' extra pace to get ahead when they stop.

Degradation How quickly a tyre loses grip and lap time as it wears.

Straight Mode 2026 active aero: wings flatten to cut drag in designated zones. Replaces DRS.

Overcut Staying out longer than a rival to gain time while they warm up new tyres or sit in traffic.

VSC Virtual Safety Car: everyone must slow to a set pace; positions are frozen and no one may overtake.

Overtake Mode Extra electrical energy for a car within one second of the car ahead at the detection point.

Pit window The range of laps when a stop makes strategic sense.

Safety Car A physical car leads the field at reduced speed, bunching everyone up behind it.

Parc fermé From qualifying until the race, cars cannot be changed without a penalty.

VERIFIED official source MEASURED computed from timing data or the outline ESTIMATE sourced estimate ANALYSIS our editorial view

03 · THE STRATEGY DESK

What a pit stop really costs

Time in the pit lane is not the same as time lost. What matters is the race time a stop costs compared with staying out, and that changes when the race is neutralised.

CONDITIONS	TIME IN PIT LANE	NET RACE-TIME LOSS	SAVING VS GREEN
Green flag	about 23 s MEASURED	about 22 s ESTIMATE	–
Virtual Safety Car	about 23 s MEASURED	about 13–18 s ESTIMATE	about 4–9 s
Safety Car	about 23 s MEASURED	about 9–14 s ESTIMATE	about 8–13 s

- Time in the pit lane is measured: the median from pit entry to pit exit at Mexico City was 22.6–23.2 s in every race from 2019 to 2025 except 2023, when stops under a red flag skew it (f1db timing data). It does not change under a VSC or Safety Car because the pit-lane speed limit still applies.
- Net race-time loss is what a stop costs compared with staying out. Formula 1's 2025 preview put it at about 21.9 s here.
- The VSC and Safety Car figures apply published estimates of the saving (roughly 17–40% under a VSC and 35–60% behind the Safety Car) to that 21.9 s. They are illustrative ranges, not Mexico City measurements.

TYRE STRATEGY VERIFIED

Pirelli says the track's low severity could favour one stop. If graining sets in on the new asphalt (Turns 7 to 1), a medium and soft combination makes two stops more attractive. A stop costs about 22 seconds.

One stop
Pirelli's base case — Favoured on a low-severity track; Pirelli has not published the compound order or lap windows.

Two stops
If graining bites — Medium → Soft — Mediums and softs, if the new asphalt makes graining significant.

PACE GAP PER LAP — Not published by Pirelli for this race.

Soft (C5) Medium (C4) Hard (C3) Pirelli qualifying release, 31 Oct 2026, as reported; pit-stop cost about 22 s.

ONE STOP OR TWO?

2023	**Red flag**	Stops from lap 11; most of the top 10 then changed tyres under the red flag after Magnussen's lap-33 crash MEASURED
2024	**One stop**	Nine of the top 10; stops between laps 26 and 39 MEASURED
2025	**Mixed**	Five one-stops and five two-stops in the top 10; stops between laps 22 and 48 MEASURED

Pirelli has nominated C3 (hard), C4 (medium) and C5 (soft), the softest three in its range and one step softer than last year. VERIFIED

UNDERCUT AND OVERCUT

Undercut: pit first and use the new tyres' extra grip to gain the time you lose in the pit lane before your rival stops. It works best when new tyres are much faster than worn ones.

Overcut: stay out longer and gain time on a clear track while your rival is held up on cold new tyres or in traffic. It works best when tyres warm up slowly or the pitting car rejoins in traffic.

IF THE VSC OR SAFETY CAR COMES OUT

A VSC or Safety Car inside the pit window makes a stop cheaper for everyone, so the leaders often pit together and little changes. The real swing comes when it falls just before a team's planned stop, or when a rival has already stopped under green. A Safety Car early in the race can make a one-stop too long and force a second stop. ANALYSIS

What to Watch

1. The start. The run to Turn 1 is long enough for slipstreams to reshuffle the top five before the first braking zone.
2. Antonelli's position. Ninth or better and the title is decided; watch where he runs when the stops shake out.
3. Graining on the soft compounds. Early stops for drivers sliding in the esses would point to two stops.

04 · THE VIEWER'S BRIEFING

Your race-day reference

14:00 CST — LIGHTS OUT · SUNDAY 1 NOVEMBER 2026 CST (UTC-6), LOCAL TIME IN MEXICO CITY

Weekend schedule VERIFIED

Fri 30 Oct	Practice 1	12:30 CST
Fri 30 Oct	Practice 2	16:00 CST
Sat 31 Oct	Practice 3	11:30 CST
Sat 31 Oct	Qualifying	15:00 CST
Sun 1 Nov	**Grand Prix (71 laps)**	**14:00 CST**

Starting grid

1	Lewis Hamilton		2	George Russell
3	Charles Leclerc		4	Kimi Antonelli
5	Max Verstappen	Q4, −1 place	6	Lando Norris
7	Isack Hadjar		8	Arvid Lindblad
9	Pierre Gasly		10	Nico Hülkenberg
11	Franco Colapinto		12	Oscar Piastri
13	Gabriel Bortoleto		14	Oliver Bearman
15	Carlos Sainz		16	Alexander Albon
17	Fernando Alonso	in doubt	18	Ryo Hirakawa debut
19	Lance Stroll		20	Sergio Pérez
21	Liam Lawson	DSQ quali	22	Valtteri Bottas −50 places

After announced penalties (in red); the FIA confirms the grid before the race. Pole: Hamilton, 1:16.514. Hirakawa replaces Ocon at Haas.

Key battles

The title	Antonelli 365, Russell 242: 123 clear, 125 left.
Runner-up	Russell 242, Hamilton 241, Verstappen 236, Leclerc 233.
Constructors P3	Red Bull 355, McLaren 355 (countback).
Constructors P5	Racing Bulls 102 vs Alpine 69.

Standings entering the race VERIFIED

POS	DRIVER	PTS
1	Kimi Antonelli	365
2	George Russell	242
3	Lewis Hamilton	241
4	Max Verstappen	236
5	Charles Leclerc	233
6	Lando Norris	211
7	Oscar Piastri	144
8	Isack Hadjar	105
9	Liam Lawson	77
10	Pierre Gasly	42

POS	CONSTRUCTOR	PTS
1	Mercedes	607
2	Ferrari	474
3	Red Bull	355
4	McLaren	355
5	Racing Bulls	102

Five things to watch

1. The run to Turn 1, the longest to a first corner all year. Slipstreams can make it three wide on lap one.
2. The title maths. Ninth or better makes Antonelli champion; with no points, only a win for Russell or Hamilton keeps it going.
3. Thin air. Cooling is tight at altitude; watch for brake and power-unit problems in the second half.
4. Pérez's home crowd in the stadium section, in his first season with Cadillac.
5. Red Bull and McLaren, level on 355, fighting for third in the Constructors'.

JP'S PREDICTION

I believe Mexico will be a challenge for these 2026 cars, with the high altitude and temperatures testing the new engines. Overtaking might be at a premium, as the tight, twisty nature of the back end of the lap will promote dirty air. Strategy should be the most intriguing part of the Grand Prix. I have Lewis Hamilton taking his second victory of the season.

— JP

Sources (last verified 1 November 2026)

Circuit facts: Formula1.com: formula1.com

Pirelli compounds: Scuderiafans: scuderiafans.com

f1db, results and pit stops 2019–2025 (CC BY 4.0): github.com

f1-circuits, track outline (MIT): github.com

VSC and SC savings: FormulaDream; Race Sundays: formuladream.app

Session times: RacingNews365: racingnews365.com

Standings after Round 18 (checked against f1db): github.com

2026 aero rules: ESPN; Motor Sport: motorsportmagazine.com

Pit loss 21.9 s: Formula1.com: formula1.com

Grid: Motorsport.com; Formula1.com: formula1.com

Penalties: Grande Premio; PlanetF1: grandepremio.com

Aero zones: FIA map via PlanetF1: planetf1.com

Pirelli qualifying release: press.pirelli.com

Circuit guide: Formula1.com: formula1.com